ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Manufacturing English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.

- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.

- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.

- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.

- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

5 Whys
Root-cause method that repeatedly asks why a problem occurred until the team reaches a controllable underlying cause.

8D
Eight-discipline problem-solving report used to contain a problem, identify root cause, implement corrective action, and prevent recurrence.

andon
A visual or audible production signal that draws attention to status or a problem.

changeover
The work and time needed to switch equipment or a line to another product or setup.

constraint
A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible.

containment
Action intended to limit the spread or effect of a problem while it is addressed.

cycle time
The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle.

defect
Failure, flaw, nonconformance, or error that prevents an output from meeting requirements.

deviation
A departure from an approved process, requirement, or expected condition.

downtime
Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

EHS
Environment, health, and safety: organizational functions addressing environmental and workplace risks.

escalation
Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.

fishbone
A cause-and-effect diagram used to organize possible contributors to a problem.

handoff
Transfer of work, responsibility, information, or risk from one person or team to another.

incoming inspection
A check of received materials or components against specified requirements.

kaizen
Continuous improvement through recurring examination and adjustment of work processes.

lockout/tagout
Procedures for controlling hazardous energy during specified work; actual steps must follow approved safety requirements.

MTBF
Mean time between failures: average operating time between failures for a defined repairable system.

near miss
An event that could have caused harm but did not result in the specified harmful outcome.

owner
Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

preventive maintenance
Planned work intended to reduce failures and maintain equipment condition.

rework
Additional processing intended to make nonconforming work meet requirements.

root cause
Underlying reason a problem occurred, not merely the visible symptom.

scrap
Material or product that cannot be used as intended and is removed from the relevant production output.

spare parts
Replacement components kept available for maintenance or repair.

specification
A detailed statement of required characteristics, performance, or materials.

standard work

The documented current method for performing a task consistently.

stop work

A call or authorized action to pause work when a safety concern requires attention under local procedures.

supplier quality

How well supplied goods and supplier processes meet specified requirements.

throughput

Amount of work, patients, goods, cases, or transactions completed in a period of time.

value stream

The sequence of activities involved in delivering a product or service to a customer.

waste

Activity or material that consumes resources without adding the intended value.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed ... .

The effect was ... . What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that ... .

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm ... .

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is ... .

The record shows ... .

Please confirm who has accepted ... .

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Production Flow and Daily Management

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

02 | Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

03 | Defects, Scrap, and Rework

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

04 | Root Cause and Corrective Action

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

05 | Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

06 | EHS and Safety Communication

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

07 | Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

08 | Shift Handoffs and Escalation

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.